7

INDIA AND THE SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION

P. Stobdan

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) has certainly emerged as the most important regional grouping in the Eurasian region. Yet multiple conflicting interests intersect at the SCO forum, ranging from regional issues to global conflicts, as Eurasia has once again become a contested region among the great powers. India has in recent decades not featured prominently in the Eurasian geopolitical equilibrium, even though regional states perceive India as a potential countervailing factor for the region. However, Central Asian states started to view India as conspicuously lacking a framework or not being able to find itself a place in any of the concentric rings that outside actors had embossed on the region. Still, from India's perspective, Central Asia formed a critical and paramount strategic component in its thinking, both due to the Afghanistan–Pakistan angle and because of China's growing influence.

India's entry into the SCO, first as an observer in 2005 and then through full membership in 2017, has been about increasing its political, economic, and security stakes in